

Introduction

Windows 7, which was released to manufacturing on July 22, 2009, and reached general retail availability on October 22, 2009, played a major part in driving revenue up for Microsoft. The company generated \$62.48 billion in revenue over the 2009-2010 fiscal year, a 7 per cent increase from the year prior, and its highest revenue ever on the books. To put things into perspective, in the nine months since its launch, Microsoft has sold 175 million copies of Windows 7 – about 638,600 copies every day – or in even more stark terms, seven copies every second. Now that's incredible!

Windows 7 did not introduce a lot of new features and was intended to be a more focused, incremental upgrade to the Windows line, with the goal of being compatible with applications and hardware with which Windows Vista is already compatible. But its reception by the community in general was in stark contrast to Windows Vista's. In only eight hours after pre-ordering began on Amazon, the orders surpassed the demand Windows Vista had in its first 17 weeks, making it the highest-grossing pre-order in Amazon's history. It took Windows 7 only two weeks to surpass the market share of Apple's Mac OS X Snow Leopard operating system. Windows 7 reached a 4 per cent market share in less than three weeks. In comparison, it took Windows Vista seven months to reach the same mark.

All the stats and speculation aside, we bring this Fast Track to Windows 7 to ease you into the operating system, which is most-likely to be bundled with your present laptop/netbook or the next one if you plan to buy in the next couple of years. We hope to cover everything from different ways of installing Windows 7, customising your system to your liking, maintaining it to troubleshooting common problems.

If you still haven't upgraded to Windows 7, the first three chapters serve as an excellent guide to deciding whether you need this, which